Sunset at the Wrong Time

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 5, Episode 1

The garden keeper opened the illustrated maintenance guide beside a chime that rang at the wrong point in the garden's cycle. Nib listened carefully and proposed a larger bell. Lark watched the moving wheel instead. A louder wrong-time chime would still ring at the wrong time.

“A louder noon,” Nib suggested hopefully. “A better explanation,” Lark replied thoughtfully.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **boat**

“A longer word can contain two familiar closed chunks,” Lark modeled clearly. “Read sun, then set. Join sun-set into sunset, then think about the whole meaning. Breaking a word helps us read it; joining it again helps us understand it.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try sunset. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read sunset on the guide's cycle picture,” Lark invited gently. “Does that picture match the moment when we heard the chime?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **The sun is up. The bell did not ring at sunset.**

“Does the passage say the bell rang at sunset?” Lark asked gently. “Which word changes that claim?”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Lark recorded the observed mismatch without naming a cause. Nib drew the wheel mark where it had actually been, not where he expected it. The keeper agreed to another look the next morning. For today they had a useful question and an honest first note, rather than a louder bell.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write sunset beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Your first garden journal page kept observation separate from explanation. Before inspecting the mechanism, the crew would need a dry, steady place to open its heavy guide.